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US expands strikes to Iran's north

Iran threatens wider retaliation; India halts seafarer deployment

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

The United States widened its military campaign against Iran early yesterday, launching strikes deeper into the country and firing on a merchant vessel accused of attempting to breach the US naval blockade, as the conflict showed fresh signs of escalation.

For the first time in the latest round of fighting, US strikes reached areas around Tehran, while Iranian state media reported attacks in Semnan province, home to the country's ballistic missile production and space programme. Additional strikes were reported in Hamed-

an, Hormozgan, Khuzestan, Lorestan, Markazi, and Sistan and Baluchestan provinces. The US military also said it fired on the Curaçao-flagged tanker Belma after it allegedly ignored repeated warnings while heading towards Kharg Island, Iran's main oil export terminal. A missile struck the vessel's smokestack, disabling the ship, according to US officials.

Iran's response

Iran responded by launching missiles and drones at US allies in the region and warned it could broaden its attacks if Washington targets critical infrastructure. Colonel Ebrahim Zolfaghari, spokesman for Iran's Khatam Al-Anbiya Central Headquarters, warned that "all the infrastructure in the region" would be targeted if President Donald Trump followed through on threats to strike Iranian

bridges and power plants. The renewed fighting has effectively ended last month's interim agreement and raised fears of a wider regional conflict centred on the Strait of Hormuz.

The UAE strongly condemned Iran's latest missile and drone attacks targeting Bahrain, Kuwait and Jordan, describing them as a flagrant violation of the sovereignty of the three countries and a threat to regional security.

Separately, a drone struck a cargo ship carrying American-branded vehicles off Iraq's southern port of Basra, according to Iraqi security officials.

Amid growing security concerns, India has directed shipping companies to stop deploying Indian seafarers on vessels transiting the Strait of Hormuz until further notice, citing heightened risks in the Gulf.

SEE ALSO P6

Dubai issues 1.052m residency permits in H1

GDRFA Dubai also grants 66,078 Golden Visas

DUBAI

BY AGHADDIR ALI
Senior Reporter

The General Directorate of Residency and Foreigners Affairs (GDRFA Dubai) issued around 1.052 million new residency permits, and completed over 5 million entry permit transactions during the first six months of the year.

During the same period, GDRFA Dubai also renewed 910,552 residence permits, bringing the total number of transactions to more than 7 million.

Targeting specialists

It also granted 66,078 Golden Visas, the programme which targets investors, entrepreneurs, scientists, specialists, outstanding students and graduates, creative talents, sports professionals and humanitarian pioneers.

GDRFA Dubai also clarified

the requirements for the UAE's five-year multiple-entry tourist visa, which allows visitors of all nationalities to enter the country multiple times without the need for a sponsor or host.

The self-sponsored visa is valid for five years and permits multiple entries and exits during that period. Visitors can stay in the UAE for up to 90 days on each visit, with the option to extend their stay for a further 90 days. However, the total period spent in the country must not exceed 180 days in a year.

SEE ALSO P2

UAE unveils new licensing rules for universities

DATA-DRIVEN OVERSIGHT SYSTEM AND COMMON STANDARDS INTRODUCED

DUBAI

BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

The UAE has introduced a unified national framework to regulate the licensing of universities and colleges, a move aimed at raising academic standards, strengthening governance and simplifying oversight across the country's higher education sector, including institutions in free zones.

Approved by His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, the framework introduces a data-driven oversight system and sets common standards for institutions operating both on the mainland and in free zones.

Single national reference

The framework, issued under the Federal Decree-Law on Higher Education and Scientific Research, establishes a single national reference for licensing higher education institutions (HEIs).

It aims to ensure compliance with national standards while respecting the mandates of local authorities responsible for regulating institutions in their respective jurisdictions.

The move is designed to strengthen institutional governance, simplify licensing procedures, improve the stu-

dent experience and foster stronger partnerships between universities and key economic sectors.

It also seeks to enhance the quality and efficiency of higher education, supporting the UAE's ambition to become a global hub for education and scientific research.

Key feature

A key feature of the framework is the introduction of a data-driven monitoring system through electronic integration between higher education institutions and national records maintained by the Ministry of Higher Education and Scientific Research (MoHESR). The system will provide regulators with accurate, up-to-date information to support evidence-based oversight while ensuring coordination with local authorities overseeing institutions in free zones.

The framework sets out comprehensive regulatory requirements covering every stage of institutional licensing. It also defines governance and ownership structures.

MoHESR said the framework will enhance the readiness of higher education institutions to meet future challenges, strengthen coordination with local authorities and help develop a skilled national talent pipeline that meets labour market needs while reinforcing the UAE's global competitiveness in higher education.

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